1
ADVENT OF COVID-19

15 JANUARY 2020

INDIA | 0 ACTIVE CASES | 0 DEATHS

WORLD | 42 ACTIVE CASES | 2 DEATHS[1]

The Indian Intelligence, right from December 2019, was privy to hushed chatter coming in from the Hubei province of China. The National Security Advisor (NSA), Ajit Doval, all of 74, was sifting through the messages, calls and reports from a global network of resources he had developed over his 53-year-long career as an Indian Police Services (IPS) officer. All emerging intelligence showed multiple cases of a new, mysterious pneumonia outbreak around a seafood and live animal market in Wuhan, a Chinese city with a population of 8 million.[2] Sources informed him about several cases of hospitalization being kept under wraps. What truly concerned the Indian intelligence was the Wuhan Institute of Virology's location—its proximity to the hospitals where these patients with the mysterious pneumonia were being admitted and to the wet market. Doval's internal radar, trained to perfection, after years of experience in the Intelligence Bureau and over six years as Prime Minister Narendra Modi's NSA, immediately beeped, alerting him that these cases possibly pointed to an emergence of a new virus. It was clear that the origins of this would have to be closely probed to reveal if it was natural or man-made. Also, it would be crucial to probe if it had escaped or was let out.

After working closely with PM Modi for an extended period of time, he knew that the prime minister truly believed that Indians slept peacefully at night trusting that the government was keeping the nation safe. They took solace in the fact that if disaster struck, our defence forces in uniform,